depart, but I already want you to write down what I'm about to say to you: the Persians do not like our presence there. They believe they have already learned all they can from us and that they can do their work now without our help. They are looking for a reason or an excuse to get us out of there. As for you, I want you to note that even if you don't succeed in adding any particular value, I forbid you to come back from there with the key." By the word *key,* he meant, of course, our presence in the territory: I could not permit any developments that might lead to the withdrawal of Israeli intelligence personnel from Iran.

My heart skipped a beat and I left the office.

I later understood why Meir attached such importance to the "key." The first reason was related to Israel's national security doctrine, as defined by its founding father David Ben-Gurion. One of the cornerstones of this doctrine was the "triangle theory." Ben-Gurion believed that Israel, surrounded by enemies, needed regional allies in its outer circle, so in a relatively short time the two triangles—the northern and the southern—were formed. The "northern triangle" consisted of Jerusalem, Ankara, and Tehran. The "southern triangle" was made up of Jerusalem, Khartoum, and Addis Ababa. (After the coup in Sudan in 1969, Khartoum withdrew from the triangle and was replaced by the Moroccan capital of Rabat.) These triangles, which operated for years with countries that did not have diplomatic relations with Israel and which, except for Ethiopia, were mostly Arab and Muslim, dealt not only with security and intelligence matters but with all the issues that exist between countries with diplomatic relations and that are usually handled by the countries' foreign ministries. From its inception, the Mossad was trusted to represent Israel in countries with which it had no diplomatic relations, and in all matters, not only in intelligence. The presence of our agency was one of the most important anchors in the northern triangle, and its existence was in danger, which explained Meir Amit's instructions that I must under no circumstances return home with the key!

The second reason for the "key's" importance lay in the extraordinary value of the intelligence product that our "foreign outposts" provided the State of Israel. The tripartite alliances allowed Israel, surrounded by enemies on all sides, close contact with the enemy states. In the Cold War era, the two superpowers competed for influence in the Middle East. The Soviet Union's first successful military penetration was in Iraq, whose army